JGA Payroll Research Plan

Proposed scope and practitioner questions

Prepared for Nick Day and Mark • Version 0.2 for review

We propose a report that connects what payroll leaders want to improve with the decisions that fund, delay or stop change. This pack sets out the readership, chapter structure and questions for review before practitioner collection begins.

The central research question

What do payroll leaders need, and what determines whether those needs become approved and delivered investment?

Who the report is for

Proposed primary readers are senior employer-side payroll leaders and the finance, HR and technology decision-makers who assess payroll investment. Start with UK-relevant responsibilities, including international remits. Employer-side users of outsourced payroll are included.

How the evidence will be built

- Review and reference existing industry research, then investigate specific decision cases rather than repeat a broad trends survey.
- Target 6–10 distinct verified senior payroll practitioner contributions through JGA introductions, subject to availability and permission.
- Explore unresolved needs, including those never proposed internally. Where available, examine one recent decision or substantive milestone, including success, renewal, delay, rejection and abandonment.
- Synthesize the evidence into a Payroll Investment Decision Framework. Qualitative contributions explain experiences; they do not establish representative market percentages.

What we need you to review

Please confirm the proposed audience and geography, chapter coverage and core questions. On page 5, we set out the introduction route, materials and dates to agree. The separate two-page prospectus can then support feedback from selected contacts.

Proposed report structure

Working title: The Payroll Investment and Transformation Report 2027. The edition year describes its planning focus; source and fieldwork dates will be recorded accurately.

The design target is approximately 20–24 pages including methods and references, adjusted to the evidence rather than used as a fixed limit. An executive summary opens the publication.

Part One What leaders want

1 Operating reality. What works, where friction occurs and who is affected, with brief historical context on recurring ambitions and changed conditions.

2 Technology and service needs. Capability, fit, affordability and readiness gaps, including needs never proposed. Examine workarounds across people, systems, services and data handoffs.

3 Priorities and commitment. The next 12–24 months: desired, evaluated, planned and funded work, plus dated signals and conditions that could change priorities.

Part Two How investment decisions happen

4 The decision pathway. Who recommends, sponsors, funds, approves or can stop a proposal, and where conditions enter the process.

5 The business case. Intended value, baseline, affordability, cost scope and who benefits; which evidence decision-makers request and what appears to influence the decision.

6 Progress and constraints. What enables or blocks progress, and how go-live differs from observed improvement. Explain delay, decline or abandonment and any result assessment.

7 Staying or switching. When renewal, an alternative supplier, a process change or deliberate no change is the chosen option.

Conclusion From Ambition to Investment

8 The practical framework. A repeatable route from an operational need to a credible case, decision and delivery review, grounded in the research.

Methods, references and evidence notes will make source populations, dates and permissions clear. Proposed case summaries and original graphics will be built from the collected evidence. No validated confidence index is assumed for this first edition.

Practitioner questions one to seven

Two context questions precede the guide. Ask open questions first; follow-ups are selective. Contributors may skip questions or avoid confidential details.

1 Role in decisions

What is your role in decisions about payroll technology, providers or major process changes?

Follow-up: recommending, evaluating, implementing or approving.

2 Operating context

How is payroll currently delivered in your area of responsibility?

Clarify broad scale, countries and delivery model. For outsourced/mixed delivery, ask what work remains internal.

3 Improvement priority

What, if anything, would you most like to improve about payroll in your organisation?

Follow-up: why it matters, who is affected and what already works well.

4 Unmet needs

Where, if anywhere, do the payroll technology or services you use or have recently evaluated fall short of your needs?

Ask for an example and workaround. Clarify fit, cost or readiness where relevant; no significant shortfall is a valid answer.

5 Future priorities

Which payroll improvements, if any, do you expect your organisation to prioritise over the next 12–24 months?

For up to two priorities, clarify stage and funding. Ask what could change the priority. If technology arises, clarify its actual task and stage of use.

6 Recent decision

Thinking about the past 24 months, what is the most recent payroll investment, provider renewal or proposed change in which you had direct involvement?

Record dates and involvement; people/capability changes and recent decision milestones in older programmes can qualify. If no case is recalled, ask whether a need was raised, then what happened or what prevented it. Resume 7–13 if an eligible recent case emerges; otherwise go to 14. Keep never-raised needs and older cases separate. Respect a choice not to share.

7 Decision reached

What decision had been reached on that proposal as of today?

Record approval, decline, deferral, withdrawal, pending or no formal approval required. Separately record delivery status and any change in the decision.

Practitioner questions eight to fourteen

Questions 8–13 refer to the same recent case. The final question is open to every eligible contributor.

8 Original trigger

What prompted this proposal or review?

Ask what improvement was intended and how success would be recognised. Clarify any deadline, lifecycle or discretionary trigger.

9 Authority and influence

Who had the authority to approve or stop the proposal?

Follow-up: sponsor, budget owner, sign-off and veto roles. Record roles rather than names.

10 Evidence requested

What evidence, if any, was requested to assess the proposal?

Select relevant follow-ups: baseline/measure, cost scope, who benefits, risk and capacity. Distinguish released time from reduced spending.

11 Evidence that mattered

Which evidence, if any, appeared to influence the decision most?

If pending, ask what evidence has influenced the assessment so far. If deferred, retain the main question. For both, also ask what evidence is still needed.

12 Alternatives and choice

What other options were considered?

Ask which option was selected and why. Clarify preferred retention versus transition or contract constraints where relevant.

13 Conditions and constraints

What conditions or concerns, if any, most affected whether or when the proposal could proceed?

Ask what enabled progress too. Where delivery permits, ask what changed, who assesses it and where any released capacity went. Keep expectations, go-live and observed results separate; not yet assessed is valid.

14 Next research question

What is one question about payroll investment that you think the profession should answer next?

Optional follow-up: advice for another payroll leader facing a similar decision.

Introductions and next decisions

Who would be useful to involve

Please forward the brief below to senior employer-side payroll leaders with direct involvement in technology, provider or major process decisions. We will seek varied operating models and outcomes, including successful change and sensible renewal. People without a recent case can contribute on needs and priorities.

Suggested introduction brief

JGA is commissioning The Payroll Investment and Transformation Report 2027, with research support from Riseklix. We are exploring what payroll leaders want to improve and what makes payroll investment get approved, delayed or abandoned.

We would value your perspective through a structured conversation or an equivalent written response, ideally drawing on a decision or substantive milestone from the past 24 months. We also welcome needs that have not become proposals. Participation is voluntary; you can skip questions or avoid confidential details.

The findings are intended for a JGA publication that may also be commercially licensed. Any named quotation or identification of your employer would require separate permission. Would you be open to contributing? We can share the questions and practical arrangements before you decide.

The Table is a separate feasibility question

Alongside the report, we will assess research-only licensing and an event-supported research model. Up to four exploratory conversations are planned, ideally two potential commercial buyers and two prospective council members. Council members count toward the 6–10 only where they also provide an eligible, permissioned report contribution; each person is counted once.

Inputs and timing to agree

- Confirm the readership, geography, outline and questions, plus any essential topic we have missed.
- Nominate an introduction coordinator and supply JGA brand assets or publication examples.
- Agree collection tools, permissions and access arrangements before participant data is collected. Confirm the conversation length after a timing check.
- Confirm the kickoff, first-week checkpoint and review date. The working plan remains approximately three working weeks from the agreed kickoff, subject to timely access and feedback.

Once the focus and collection arrangements are agreed, we will retain the approved version and begin introductions and practitioner collection.